司马光砸缸

爷爷讲的两个老故事

Sima Guang Breaks the Jar

Two old stories from Grandpa

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 3 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 乐乐[†]今年八岁，他有一个五岁的妹妹，叫小米[‡]。每个周末，他们都去爷爷奶奶家。爷爷以前是中学老师，最会讲故事。

不想给妹妹

2 这个星期天，乐乐带来了一大包糖。这是爸爸从上海[§]带回来的，红的、绿的、黄的，一共有二十四块。乐乐坐在沙发上，一块一块地数着。小米跑过来说：“哥哥，给我一块，好不好？”“不给！”乐乐马上把糖放进了自己的书包里，“这是爸爸给我的，不是给你的。”小米听了，大哭起来。

3 小米越哭越大声，爷爷正在看报纸，不得不放下了手里的报纸。

† 乐乐 *Lèle* Lele
‡ 小米 *Xiǎomǐ* Xiaomi
§ 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai

Lele was eight, and he had a five-year-old little sister called Xiaomi. Every weekend they went to their grandparents' home. Grandpa used to be a secondary-school teacher, and nobody told stories better than he did. 1

Not Sharing with His Sister

This Sunday, Lele brought along a big bag of sweets. Dad had brought them back from Shanghai: red ones, green ones, yellow ones, twenty-four in all. Lele sat on the sofa, counting them one by one. Xiaomi ran over and said, "Can I have one, please?" "No!" Lele immediately stuffed the sweets into his schoolbag. "Dad gave them to me, not to you." When Xiaomi heard this, she burst into tears. 2

Xiaomi cried louder and louder, and Grandpa, who was reading the paper, had to put it down. 3

3 他没有生气，只是笑着说：“乐乐[†]，你过来。爷爷给你讲两个老故事。听完了，你再决定给不给妹妹，好不好？”因为乐乐最喜欢听爷爷讲故事，所以他马上坐到了爷爷身边。小米[‡]也不哭了，跟着坐了过来。

大水缸[§]

4 “差不多一千年以前，宋朝[¶]有一个小男孩，叫司马光[*]。”爷爷说。那时候，很多院子里都放着大水缸，里面装满了水。有一天，七岁的司马光和几个小朋友在院子里玩。有一个孩子爬到了水缸上面，可是他没有站好，掉进了缸[#]里。缸很深，水比他还高。他在水里一边叫一边动，可是一会儿头就到了水下面。

† 乐乐 *Lèle* Lele
‡ 小米 *Xiǎomǐ* Xiaomi
§ 水缸 *shuǐgāng* big water jar
¶ 宋朝 *Sòngcháo* the Song dynasty
* 司马光 *Sīmǎ Guāng* Sima Guang (1019–1086)
缸 *gāng* jar

He didn't get angry. He just smiled and said, "Lele, come here. Grandpa will 3
tell you two old stories. When you've heard them, you can decide whether to give your sister any. All right?" Lele loved listening to Grandpa's stories more than anything, so he sat down next to him at once. Xiaomi stopped crying too and came over to sit with them.

The Big Water Jar

"About a thousand years ago, in the Song dynasty, there was a little boy 4
called Sima Guang," said Grandpa. In those days many courtyards had a big water jar standing in them, filled to the brim with water. One day, seven-year-old Sima Guang was playing in a courtyard with some other children. One boy climbed up onto the edge of the jar, lost his footing, and fell in. The jar was deep, and the water was deeper than he was tall. He shouted and thrashed about, but soon his head went under.

5 别的孩子都很害怕，有的大哭，有的跑去叫大人。可是大人们离得很远，等他们来了，就太晚了。只有司马光[†]没有跑。他看了看旁边，找到一块大石头，用两只手举起来，向水缸[‡]打了过去。一下，两下，三下……水缸被打破了。水从缸[§]里流了出来，那个孩子也得救了。

6 “他为什么不把那个孩子拉上来？”乐乐[¶]问。“因为缸太高，司马光他们都是小孩子，手不够长，所以拉不上来。”爷爷说，“去叫大人又太慢，司马光不得不想一个别的办法。”“可是水缸也被他打坏了啊。”乐乐说，“一口水缸一定很贵吧？”“当然贵。可是在司马光心里，水缸再贵，也没有人重要。”

7 后来，这件事被很多人知道了，大家都说这个孩子很会想办法。

† 司马光 *Sīmǎ Guāng* Sima Guang (1019–1086)
‡ 水缸 *shuǐgāng* big water jar
§ 缸 *gāng* jar
¶ 乐乐 *Lèle* Lele

The other children were terrified. Some burst into tears, and some ran off 5
to fetch the grown-ups. But the grown-ups were a long way off, and by the time they came it would be too late. Only Sima Guang didn't run. He looked around, found a big stone, lifted it with both hands, and smashed it against the jar. Once, twice, three times... and the jar broke. The water poured out of the jar, and the boy was saved.

"Why didn't he just pull the boy out?" asked Lele. "Because the jar was too 6
high, and Sima Guang and the others were only small children. Their arms weren't long enough, so they couldn't pull him out," said Grandpa. "And fetching the grown-ups would take too long, so Sima Guang had to think of another way." "But he broke the jar," said Lele. "A water jar must cost a lot, right?" "Of course it did. But to Sima Guang, however much a jar cost, it wasn't as important as a person."

Later, many people came to hear about it, and everyone said this boy really 7
knew how to find a way out.

7 司马光[1]长大以后，读了很多书，还和别人一起写了一部很有名的历史[2]书，叫《资治通鉴[3]》。据说，他们写了大约十九年，书里写了一千三百多年的历史。现在，还有很多中国人在读这部书。爷爷说："中国的父母很喜欢给孩子讲这个故事。他们想告诉孩子：有问题的时候，哭和跑都没有用，要先想一想还有什么别的办法。有时候，为了更重要的东西，我们不得不放下别的东西。"

孔融让梨[4]

8 "爷爷，再讲一个！"小米[5]说。"好。第二个故事更老，是汉朝[6]的，已经有一千八百多年了。"那时候，有一个孩子叫孔融[7]，他有好几个哥哥，还有一个弟弟。

1 司马光 *Sīmǎ Guāng* Sima Guang (1019–1086)
2 历史 *lìshǐ* history
3 资治通鉴 *Zīzhì Tōngjiàn* Comprehensive Mirror to Aid Government
4 孔融让梨 *Kǒng Róng ràng lí* Kong Rong gives up the bigger pears
5 小米 *Xiǎomǐ* Xiaomi
6 汉朝 *Hàncháo* the Han dynasty
7 孔融 *Kǒng Róng* Kong Rong (153–208)

When Sima Guang grew up, he read a great many books, and together with 7
others he wrote a famous history book called the Zizhi Tongjian, the "Comprehensive Mirror to Aid in Government". It is said that they spent about nineteen years writing it, and that it covers more than thirteen hundred years of history. Many Chinese people still read it today. Grandpa said, "Chinese parents love telling their children this story. They want them to learn that when there's a problem, crying and running away don't help: first think about what else you could do. And sometimes, for the sake of something more important, we have to let other things go."

Kong Rong Gives Up the Bigger Pears

"Grandpa, tell another one!" said Xiaomi. "All right. The second story is 8
even older. It's from the Han dynasty, more than eighteen hundred years ago." In those days there was a boy called Kong Rong. He had several older brothers and one younger brother.

8 孔融[†]四岁的时候，有一天，家里来了客人，送来了一些梨[‡]。父亲让孩子们自己去拿。孔融第一个走过去，可是他没有拿大的，拿了一个最小的。

9 父亲问他："这么多梨，你为什么拿最小的？"孔融说："我小，应该拿小的。我把大的留给哥哥们。"父亲又问："那你的弟弟比你还小呢？"孔融说："我是哥哥，应该让着弟弟。"后来，这个故事被写进了《三字经[§]》。到现在，中国的很多小孩子都知道"孔融让梨[¶]"。

10 乐乐[*]听完，马上说："这不对！""哪里不对？"爷爷问。"为什么小的就要拿小的梨？小孩子正在长身体，应该多吃一点儿才对！"小米[#]在旁边听了，也点了点头。爷爷笑了："你说得也有道理。那你说，孔融的哥哥们应该拿哪个？"

† 孔融 *Kǒng Róng* Kong Rong (153–208)
‡ 梨 *lí* pear
§ 三字经 *Sānzìjīng* the Three Character Classic
¶ 孔融让梨 *Kǒng Róng ràng lí* Kong Rong gives up the bigger pears
* 乐乐 *Lèle* Lele
\# 小米 *Xiǎomǐ* Xiaomi

When Kong Rong was four, a guest came to the house one day and brought some pears. Their father told the children to help themselves. Kong Rong went up first, but he didn't take a big one. He took the smallest. 8

His father asked him, "With all these pears, why did you take the smallest?" Kong Rong said, "I'm little, so I should take a little one. I'll leave the big ones for my brothers." His father asked again, "But your little brother is even smaller than you, isn't he?" Kong Rong said, "I'm his big brother, so I should let him go first." Later the story was written into the Three Character Classic, and to this day lots of Chinese children know "Kong Rong gives up the pears". 9

As soon as Lele had heard it, he said, "That's not right!" "What's not right about it?" asked Grandpa. "Why should the little one have to take the little pear? Little kids are still growing. They should get more to eat!" Xiaomi, listening beside him, nodded too. Grandpa laughed. "You have a point. So tell me, which pears should Kong Rong's older brothers take?" 10

10 “他们是哥哥，应该让着弟弟，拿小的……”乐乐[†]说到这里，突然不说话了。他想起来，自己也是哥哥。

11 爷爷又问：“孔融[‡]先说‘我小’，后来又说‘我是哥哥’。他到底是大还是小？”乐乐被问住了。他想了很久，才说：“他……不是在说大小。他是在想着别人。”“对了。”爷爷说，“让，不是说一个人永远吃小的。如果家里的人都先想着别人，那么谁拿大的、谁拿小的，就没有那么重要了。在中国人的家里，大的让小的，小的也让大的，这就是‘让’。”

乐乐的办法

12 乐乐坐在那里，想了很久。他想：司马光[§]能想出好办法，我也能。

† 乐乐 *Lèle* Lele

‡ 孔融 *Kǒng Róng* Kong Rong (153–208)

§ 司马光 *Sīmǎ Guāng* Sima Guang (1019–1086)

"They're the big brothers, so they should let the younger ones go first and take the small ones..." Lele stopped short. He had just remembered that he was a big brother too. 10

Grandpa asked another question. "First Kong Rong says 'I'm little', and then he says 'I'm the big brother'. So which is he, big or little?" That stumped Lele. He thought for a long time before he said, "He... isn't really talking about big or little. He's thinking about other people." "That's it," said Grandpa. "Giving way doesn't mean one person always gets the small one. If everyone in a family thinks of the others first, then who takes the big one and who takes the small one stops mattering so much. In a Chinese family, the big ones give way to the little ones, and the little ones give way to the big ones too. That's what giving way means." 11

Lele's Idea

Lele sat there and thought for a long time. He thought: if Sima Guang could come up with a good idea, so can I. 12

12 突然，他跳了起来：“我有办法了！”他把书包里的糖都拿了出来，分开放在桌子上，左边十二块，右边十二块。“小米[†]，”他说，“我来分，你来选。你喜欢哪一份，就拿哪一份。”

13 爷爷问：“为什么你分，她选？”乐乐[‡]说：“因为她先选，所以我不得不分得一样多。要是有一份多，她一定会拿多的那份。这样，谁也不会觉得不公平。”爷爷大笑：“好！你这个办法，司马光[§]和孔融[¶]都会喜欢的。”

14 小米看了半天，拿了左边的一份。她数了数，然后从里面拿出一块红的，给了乐乐：“哥哥，这块给你。”乐乐有点儿不好意思。他想了想，把自己那份里最大的一块给了爷爷：“爷爷，这块给您，因为您的故事讲得最好。”爷爷吃着糖，笑着说：“今天的糖特别甜。”

† 小米 *Xiǎomǐ* Xiaomi

‡ 乐乐 *Lèle* Lele

§ 司马光 *Sīmǎ Guāng* Sima Guang (1019–1086)

¶ 孔融 *Kǒng Róng* Kong Rong (153–208)

Suddenly he jumped up. "I've got it!" He took all the sweets out of his school- 12
bag and laid them out on the table in two lots: twelve on the left and twelve on the right. "Xiaomi," he said, "I divide, you choose. Whichever lot you like, you take."

Grandpa asked, "Why do you divide and she chooses?" Lele said, "Because 13
she chooses first, I have to make them exactly even. If one lot were bigger, she'd be sure to take that one. That way, nobody can feel it's unfair." Grandpa roared with laughter. "Good! Sima Guang and Kong Rong would both like that idea of yours."

Xiaomi looked for ages and then took the lot on the left. She counted them, 14
then picked out a red one and gave it to Lele. "This one's for you." Lele felt a little embarrassed. He thought for a moment, then gave the biggest sweet in his own lot to Grandpa. "Grandpa, this one's for you, because you tell the best stories." Eating the sweet, Grandpa smiled and said, "The sweets are especially sweet today."